

POLICY ON GENERAL AND HAZARDOUS WASTE MANAGEMENT

Rationale

The University of Mindanao is committed to ensuring a safe, healthy, and environmentally responsible campus by enforcing effective waste and hazardous waste management practices. Improper handling and disposal of waste, particularly hazardous materials, pose serious threats to health, safety, and the environment. This policy supports compliance with national regulations, including RA 9003 (Ecological Solid Waste Management Act) and DAO 92-29 (Hazardous Waste Management). It aligns with the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), particularly SDG 12 (Responsible Consumption and Production) and SDG 3 (Good Health and Well-being).

Scope

This policy applies to all students, faculty, staff, janitorial services, contractors, laboratories, and third-party partners within the University of Mindanao across all campuses who generate, handle, store or dispose of solid, hazardous, or healthcare waste.

Guiding Principles

1. **Waste segregation and classification.** The University of Mindanao upholds the principle of source-level waste segregation to ensure proper handling, recycling, and disposal. All waste must be classified into biodegradable, recyclable, residual, special, and health care. Corresponding color-coded bins must be used across all campuses: green for biodegradable waste, blue for recyclables, black for residual waste, red for special waste (such as electronics, busted lamps, or oil cans), and yellow for health care or infectious waste. As defined in OPM 26.06, this classification system must be strictly followed by all stakeholders to minimize environmental impact and support efficient downstream waste processing.
2. **Hazardous Waste Handling and Storage.** Hazardous wastes generated from laboratories and operational units must be handled cautiously and strictly with OPM 26.07. These wastes must be collected in compatible high-density polyethylene (HDPE) containers and labeled using laminated yellow tags, including waste type, hazard classification, volume, storage date, and waste generator information. Each laboratory or generating unit must maintain a Hazardous Waste Monitoring Form to ensure traceability. Hazardous wastes shall be stored temporarily in the Hazardous Waste Storage Facility (HWSF), which must be secured, well-ventilated, and routinely inspected for leaks or deterioration. DENR-accredited third-party haulers and treaters must conduct final collection and disposal.
3. **Spill and Emergency Preparedness.** The university adopts a proactive approach to chemical spills and hazardous waste emergencies through its Comprehensive Contingency and Specific Spill Response Plan, as mandated by OPM 26.07. Spill kits must be accessible in laboratories and critical facilities, and all personnel responding to

spills must wear appropriate personal protective equipment (PPE). In the event of a spill, affected areas must be secured, and the Pollution Control Officer (PCO) and Disaster Risk Management–Environmental Management Committee (DRM-EMC) must be immediately notified. Proper containment, neutralization, and documentation protocols must be observed, ensuring swift and safe mitigation of hazards to people and the environment.

4. **Waste Neutralization and Minimization.** To reduce the volume of hazardous waste requiring offsite treatment, laboratories are encouraged to conduct in-house neutralization of small volumes of spent acids and bases, provided they are not contaminated with heavy metals or other toxic compounds. Neutralization processes must follow the step-by-step procedures outlined in OPM 26.07, which include dilution, pH monitoring, and proper disposal down laboratory sinks only when pH levels are within the acceptable range. These activities must be conducted under fume hoods with appropriate PPE and under the supervision of qualified personnel. Any uncertainty in the procedure must be referred to the PCO before execution.
5. **Education and Awareness.** The University of Mindanao recognizes the importance of continuous education in fostering a culture of environmental stewardship. Orientation sessions for students and employees shall include briefings on proper waste handling. At the same time, the Office of Student Affairs (OSA) and Human Resource and Management Division (HRMD) will spearhead awareness campaigns each academic year. Posters, visible signage, and institutional seminars will reinforce compliance and empower all stakeholders with the knowledge necessary to support waste reduction and environmental safety.
6. **Materials Recovery and Recycling.** All recyclable and reusable waste materials must be directed to the university's Materials Recovery Facility (MRF), where sorting and storage for upcycling, resale, or offsite transport will occur. Plastic bottles, electronics, and other recyclable items that cannot be upcycled into alternative products, such as plastic lumber, may be downcycled. These processes minimize landfill burden while promoting resource recovery and innovation.
7. **Compliance with Reporting.** All generating units are responsible for submitting accurate records of hazardous waste generated, stored, or neutralized. Laboratory custodians must report chemical inventories and hazardous waste logs to the Pollution Control Officer (PCO) for proper consolidation and submission to the DENR-EMB by OPM 26.06 and 26.07. In the event of spills or incidents, immediate reporting is mandatory to the PCO, Safety Officer, and DRM-EMC. Proper documentation ensures institutional accountability, supports regulatory compliance, and guides future planning for more effective waste management systems.

Compliance

Compliance with this policy is mandatory. All units and individuals must segregate, store, and dispose of waste properly. Any violation may result in administrative action in accordance with university rules and relevant national laws. The Pollution Control Office, in coordination with the DRM-EMC and janitorial supervisors, shall monitor and enforce compliance.

Implementation and Review

The implementation of this policy shall be led by the Pollution Control Office (PCO) and the Environment Management Committee (EMC) under the UMESSH-GD Council. Regular audits shall be conducted to assess effectiveness and compliance. An annual sustainability report will be prepared to document progress, and a feedback mechanism will be established to solicit suggestions from the campus community. This policy shall be reviewed periodically by the PCO in coordination with the Physical Plant Maintenance and General Services (PPMGS), Quality Management Office (QMO), and other stakeholders in accordance with OPM 32.01. Revisions shall be officially communicated and immediately implemented upon approval.

Signed:

(Sgd) GUILLERMO P. TORRES, JR.
University President

References

OPM 26.06 – Waste Management and Segregation; Effective February 28, 2025; Rev. 2
OPM 26.07 – Disposal of Hazardous Waste; Effective October 1, 2024; Rev. 0
DAO 92-29 – Hazardous Waste Management
RA 9003 – Ecological Solid Waste Management Act
DENR-EMB Regulations